

Seminar #6: FASTING

Fasting is the absolute surrender of your self to God by means of abstaining from food, at times, even from drink.

God designed this activity wherein we bring the soulish-sensual part of our beings under the control of the Holy Spirit. *Fasting* is one way of saying, *"I am a spirit-being before I am a physical being."*

I. SHOULD ALL BELIEVERS FAST?

Yes. Fasting is not an option. Like prayer, it is part of being a Christian. (Matthew 6:6-7, 16, 17)

II. WHY MUST A BELIEVER FAST?

A. Every believer MUST fast.

We should fast...

1. that we may humble ourselves. (Psalm 35:13; 1Peter 5:6)
2. that we may come closer to God. (James 4:8)
3. that we may understand God's Word.
4. that we may find God's will and find direction for our lives. (Ezra 8:21)
5. that we may seek physical and spiritual healing. (Isaiah 58:6-8; Mark 9:29)
6. that we may intercede on others' behalf.
7. that we may ask God's supernatural intervention on a particular crisis or when a tremendous problem has risen that cannot be handled by ordinary means. (2Chronicles 20)

B. Ten specific promises of fasting (Isaiah 58:5-9, 11-12)

1. Light
2. Health
3. Righteousness
4. Glory
5. Answered Prayer
6. Continual Guidance
7. Satisfaction
8. Refreshing
9. Work that endures
10. Restoration

III. WHAT ARE THE DIFFERENT WAYS TO FAST?

- A. **Normal Fast.** Abstaining from food but not from water.
- B. **Partial Fast.** Abstaining from food for a short period of time. Example: one meal.
- C. **Absolute Fast.** Abstaining from food and drink. It is an exceptional measure for an exceptional situation. It is something reserved for God to initiate for by a supernatural visitation in spiritual emergencies.
- D. **Supernatural Fast.** Examples are:
 - *Deuteronomy 9 – Moses*
 - *Exodus 34 – Moses*
 - *Matthew 4 – Jesus*

IV. HOW SHOULD A BELIEVER PREPARE FOR A FAST?

- A. **Suggested Guidelines on Fasting:**
 - 1. Set a regular time to fast. Fasting will cause us to forget personal gain.
 - 2. Look for the best place to stay and fast.
 - 3. Do not work or do anything that would distract your communion with God.
 - 4. Be aware of the different kinds of fasting.
 - 5. Read and meditate God's Word.
 - 6. Soul-search before coming to God in prayer.
 - 7. Confess your sins before God. Ask for God's forgiveness.
 - 8. Commune with God through praise and worship.
 - 9. Fellowship with God. Let His manifested, communing presence fill your heart.
 - 10. Talk to God earnestly in prayer.
 - 11. Let God take you deeper into His love and care.
 - 12. Intercede for others.
 - 13. Present your personal requests before God.
 - 14. Sing songs of thanksgiving.
 - 15. Surrender your life and will before God.

B. Reminders for Fasting

1. We need to have the right attitude towards our body. (1 Corinthians 6:19- 20)
We need to prepare our physical bodies. The battleground during fasting is not only in the spirit but in the body as well.
2. Fasting is a very practical way to make and keep our body healthy. If we fast, many physical problems may be solved.
3. We are not fasting just because there is a need, or because deep troubles come our way.
We fast to know God more, to have fellowship with God, to have intimacy with God.
4. We also fast when the need arises and we need God's supernatural intervention for a specific prayer requests such as: national, political, economic and Church issues, etc.

V. HOW LONG SHOULD A BELIEVER FAST?

A. Do not begin with a very long fast: 1 week, 2 weeks or 40 days.

1. Begin by omitting the last meal of the day.
2. Skip the last 2 meals.
3. Then 3 meals.

B. Begin on a small scale and gradually increase the length of your fast. As you fast in the name of God, make sure that your motives are right.

VI. WHAT HAPPENS AS A BELIEVER FASTS?

- A. Extra time for Bible Reading and prayer is taken.** It is vital to make it a practice to pray before and after reading the Bible. After prayer, when the Bible is read, it anoints the spirit and gets it in line with God. The prayer that comes after Bible Reading will be much more effective.
- B. Guards are set against spiritual attack.** As God is sought, Satan either attacks spiritually or looses his forces against you. Don't you worry, nothing can possibly hurt you.

VII. HOW CAN A BELIEVER BREAK HIS FAST?

- A. After fasting, always begin with a light meal, even if you fasted for only a short meal.
- B. The longer you fast, the more gradually you must break it. If you fasted a long time (over three weeks), your stomach will be like a baby's. It actually takes a week to get back to normal food.